The tiny plastered adobe house on the ranch had been built in 1872 and it needed lots of work. On two sides, the previous owners had erected a makeshift screened porch with an ugly corrugated aluminum roof and walls made of green plastic siding. It wasn't very pretty, nor was most of the house itself, which hadn't really been lived in full-time for years and was used mostly by overnighting cattlemen.

We tore out the porch, leaving only the concrete floor, and with the help of a contractor, built a big L-shaped room with a fireplace and big windows all around. The house now had about fifteen hundred square feet, not a big house by some standards, but our new addition and the windows, which opened up wonderful views across the meadow, did wonders in giving it a greater sense of spaciousness.

With the help of Barney Barnett, a retired California highway patrolman who'd been our driver and friend in Los Angeles, and another friend, Dennis LeBlanc, we replaced well-weathered asbestos shingles on the roof with a new roof of simulated Spanish tiles on the main house as well as the new addition, giving it all the look of a nineteenth-century Mexican adobe.

Our bedroom was only nine feet by fourteen feet and before long, Nancy was feeling a little claustrophobic, so Barney and I knocked out a wall and expanded it. (My experience remodeling houses as a fourteen-year-old in Dixon never came in handier.) But we didn't stop there. We got the contractor who had rebuilt the porch to turn the bedroom into an even larger room.

From the first day we saw it, Rancho del Cielo cast a spell over us.

No place before or since has ever given Nancy and me the joy and serenity it does.

Rancho del Cielo can make you feel as if you are on a cloud looking down at the world. From the house we look across the meadow at a peak crowned with oak trees and